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INDIA PREPARES

27 JANUARY 2020

INDIA | 1 ACTIVE CASE | 0 DEATHS

WORLD | 4,835 ACTIVE CASES | 110 DEATHS

The invisible hitch-hiker made its way to India in the first known case of an infected student who had returned home from Wuhan on 23 January, before the city went into lockdown. Patient Zero, a 20-year-old female, presented herself at the Emergency Department in General Hospital in Thrissur (Kerala) with a one-day history of dry cough and sore throat.[1] In her history, she said that she was asymptomatic between 23 and 26 January. She had most likely been exposed to the virus in the train from Wuhan to Kunming during her journey back home, where she noticed people with respiratory symptoms in the railway station and train. Her sample was sent to the NIV laboratory in Pune and was reported positive for COVID-19 infection to the District Control Cell. Detailed contact tracing was carried out by the Government Medical College along with district health authorities. She was placed in the isolation ward at the hospital and her samples sent for testing every alternate day. By day 17, she had tested negative.[2]

The enemy was at the doorstep. This was no surprise. On 26 January, the mayor of Wuhan had acknowledged that five million people had left the city in the week before the Chinese government locked it down.[3] As Bloomberg News dubs it, the ‘world’s biggest human migration’—the Chinese New Year celebration—would begin on 24 January, spanning 16 days, with an estimate of about three billion trips taken within China and to other countries for the holiday.[4] Despite the raging march of the virus, the